

OTCHO: FINGERBOARDING & HARSH NOISE

note from the editor

Hello, fingerboarders and quirked-up baddies. Welcome to Issue 6 of OTCHO. In each edition, we explore fingerboarding from an artistic perspective, highlighting its potential outside of skateboarding. Typically, we feature two or three pieces per issue, offering a range of insights into this unique subculture. However, for this edition, we have chosen to focus on a single, standout work. A blockbuster of fingerboarding, performance art and harsh noise bliss.

This particular piece was presented at Newfoundland's Sound Symposium, a biannual event that has been a fixture in St. John's since 1983, renowned for fostering experimental and interdisciplinary sound art performances.

For the 2024 edition of the symposium, artists Nick Hunt and Liam Ryan collaborated to produce a richly textured, conceptual fingerboarding performance. I had the opportunity to speak with these fools to see what on earth they were thinking.

interview conducted August 9, 2024

Andrew Hill: Could you start by describing your relationship between each other?

Liam Ryan: When we were teenagers, we worked together at Berg's Ice Cream in Conception Bay South. We had already started hanging out in the music room, playing guitar, but I feel like we really became friends once Nick started working at Berg's. Working together turned it into a real friendship, rather than just "we jammed once in a while."

Andrew Hill: Now you're in a band?

Nick Hunt: Yeah, we've been in a few bands over the years. We play in a band called Swimming and another band called Gallery.

AH: Can you describe the fingerboard harsh noise piece?

NH: I set up a fingerboard park and Liam put microphones on certain areas of the park. On a handrail, under a quarter pipe, places like that. I would fingerboard on it to create this performance piece. Liam was taking the sounds of my fingerboarding and creating noise through various guitar pedals and other little machines, making it sound wonky and weird.

LR: We also had a live video feed at the church streaming the fingerboarding. Jacob [Cherwick], our friend who plays in Swimming with us, videotaped the piece. He had a line to a projector and the projector was behind us. This created a feedback loop of video so that people in the audience could see what was happening. Nick could see his own hands from a distance, because people weren't crowded around the table. Then it would get pretty out of hand because of all the feedback happening and it would become a bit of a visual show. It was almost unrecognizable what was actually going on. He zoomed in so far that every little movement looked very severe. It was a chaotic visual accompaniment to the piece.

NH: The camera was behind the projector, and the projector was feeding into the camera. As you pointed the camera at the projector, the image would create feedback. The colors started going nuts.

LR: The most severe moment would be when the image would feedback for so long that it would just become a white light behind us. That happened quite a lot. We're talking about putting out the video with the audio at some point.

AH: Why did you make this piece?

NH: It started as a joke¹ and then we were like, wait there is something here. I talked to the technical director of the Sound Symposium, Michelle [LaCour] and she thought it was a pretty cool idea. For us this seemed like the one festival that would encourage this kind of piece. We were diving into it, not really knowing what we were going to do.

AH: There's definitely a relationship between harsh noise and fingerboarding on a sonic level. The little tic tac noises when you're at a fingerboard event, it's like a noise show in itself.

NH: It really is.

AH: There's a contrast of harsh noise being serious and fingerboarding being kind of silly—it's a toy—but it is also meditative and can be serious in its own way. What did visitors think of the work?

LR: Lots of people being like "that looks strange" while we were setting up. They thought it was funny to see fingerboard ramps at a sound festival.

AH: I was thinking of how harsh noise is an abstraction of music. It's music without any music in it. Fingerboarding is an abstraction of skateboarding. It's this bastardized version of the actual thing. I think that's another connection between harsh noise and fingerboarding.

LR: Definitely.

AH: How would you score this piece?

LR: On my end it was completely improvised. I didn't know what I was going to do until I was up there. Even as we were setting up, I was figuring it out. I don't know if I could score it, I was really going for it. It was a lot of having to hear and see what Nick was doing, to know what worked microphone-wise.

AH: You were responding to Nick?

LR: Yeah, in a big way. He dictated the pace. I think there were six microphones. Some were contact mics and some that were normal microphones. I had them all running in different effects, and in different ways, and I would alter them if Nick was over on one side of the park. I would use the microphone that would be closest, and then I'd move accordingly. If I was using one microphone that was far away, it didn't really capture the noises enough.

When we were setting it up, I was figuring it out as we were going. We never practiced it, we only spoke about it. Even on the day of the performance I said to Nick, I was like, "I don't really know what I'm going to do."

AH: Of the different mic'd up spots, were there particular sounds that stood out to you?

LR: Yeah, Nick, I don't remember what piece it was, but the really loud one? Was the contact mic under a bank or something?

NH: The Black River Ramps pocket quarter, of course.

LR: That one was hitting hard. And the contact mic under the other ramp?

NH: Wall hip, yeah. That one was alright, too. The rail didn't work out well until the end. We figured out that by moving mics, you could get the ding off it a bit better. Grinding on the microphones themselves was a funny bit. It didn't do much sound-wise, but people were commenting on that.

LR: That was crazy because I would do some other noise shit while Nick was fingerboarding, to make it seem like it was actually doing something. Microphones just don't work like that. Or at least the ones that we were using don't work like that so people thought we were crazy.

NH: It was making a wild noise.

AH: That pocket quarter and the wall hip are both hollow. So the mic was on the inside?

LR: Yeah, we took the paper out of the quarter.

NH: I had the paper stuffed in it, you know how it is. We took it out to produce a broader range of sounds.

AH: Yeah, I always fill hollow ramps with stuff.

NH: I went on a spree recently and put a bunch of old clothes I had inside my ramps.²

AH: I don't always like to compare skateboarding and fingerboarding, but with this one, I'm curious: do you have any ideas to develop the project further? Or does it only work at this scale?

Sound Symposium XXI: Nick Hunt & Liam Ryan & Jacob Cherwick
St. John's, Newfoundland, Canada
July 22, 2024

¹This is why Sam Aironie's videos sound like he's riding on cardboard

It's worth noting that many successful fingerboard projects often start as jokes, but they grow into something more serious and meaningful. The beauty of fingerboarding lies in how it balances being a toy and a tool.

As Mike Schneider once said, "I like fingerboarding because it makes me feel like a kid."

OTCHO

LR: I think it lends itself to fingerboarding. You have a table, the hollow objects and whatnot. It's also two niches, noise and fingerboarding. With skateboarding, we could use those sports microphones. Basically like big satellite dishes with long microphones in the middle of it and you can capture just about anything with it.

NH: It's like a laser, right?

LR: It's very specific and very strong. If you were to upscale, you could do some crazy stuff like that. It would be way more work with a full size park and a bunch of people skateboarding rather than one person fingerboarding on a table.

AH: Use the satellite sports microphone on a fingerboard park!

LR: That would be wild.

AH: Would you consider this piece a field recording?

NH: In a way, yes. It's a recording of a regular fingerboard session. I didn't have any runs planned out. I sat down and did it, on autopilot.

AH: If you played the fingerboard like an instrument or if you had practiced a routine beforehand and been like "we're going to repeat this sound on the rail three times." Would that change the piece?

NH: We actually did do something related to this on the EP that we recorded. The T Pose one. Oh my god.

LR: Did we?

NH: We recorded this song where there's a bunch of random drums going on, and it was just noise from a guitar and a bunch of pedals. I did a kickflip nosegrind on the guitar and just kept it going for 40 seconds. It sounded fucked. I can definitely picture a written score for that.

LR: I forgot about that. We called it "kickflip nosegrind." That was a real random night, when you record a couple songs on a Friday night and put 'em out and never tell anybody.

AH: I think you should try to put out the audio and video from this harsh noise performance. There's not a lot of crossovers with contemporary art and fingerboarding so that's why I really wanted to talk to you guys. It's rare, in a way.

LR: We were joking when we were setting up the park. We were like, "has this ever been done before?" And then we ended up being like, all right, "this is the only time this is happening right now in the world, we can say that."

NH: Confidently.

LR: Has anyone ever done this before?³ Maybe not. Has anyone ever used a fingerboard for sound art? I'm sure there has been... but in a live setting? It was definitely a funny conversation. "We might be the only people right now, we might be the only people ever!"

AH: Now that you've set the standard, maybe someone else will perform it at a different noise music festival.

NH: Yeah, that'd be really cool. It's funny to talk about other people trying to do it. I know that one person—Pat McGinn—was asking me to work with him. "Hey, do you have two condenser microphones so that you can stereo record yourself fingerboarding from left to right?" He wanted to use it in a song or two for his next album. It was a very interesting idea, but I haven't heard if he did anything with that concept yet.

AH: We should get in touch with Pat McGinn. He was making music under Pat D'Cat. There's some really good songs. There's this one called "All This Time" by Pat D'Cat that's not uploaded anymore. It's a fucking amazing song. I haven't seen him in a while. I don't know if he still goes to Rendezvous, but we should get in touch with him and fulfill this prophecy of the two condenser mics.

NH: Yeah, totally.

AH: Could be good. Okay, thanks guys. Nick, I'll see you someday. Liam, I'm not sure if I'll ever meet you.



³See *Fingerboard Skate Park Orchestra: Amplifying the Sounds of Streeting* by Lee Walton and Derek Toomes

OTCHO is a printed magazine dedicated to the fingerboard scene, initiated by Andrew Hill in 2017. As a relatively young and underground subculture, the fingerboard community has limited published resources. OTCHO's research methodology includes the collection of oral histories and personal narratives from community members, supplemented by photo documentation from fingerboard events. Given the rapid evolution of social media, significant portions of fingerboarding history have been lost. The production of serialized, physical documentation is essential for preserving the community's historical record. To date, OTCHO has published six issues, continuing its mission to chronicle the previously untold history of fingerboarding.

Issue 6 was printed in Tallinn, Estonia and released at the WIELS Art Book Fair, October 5 & 6, 2024.

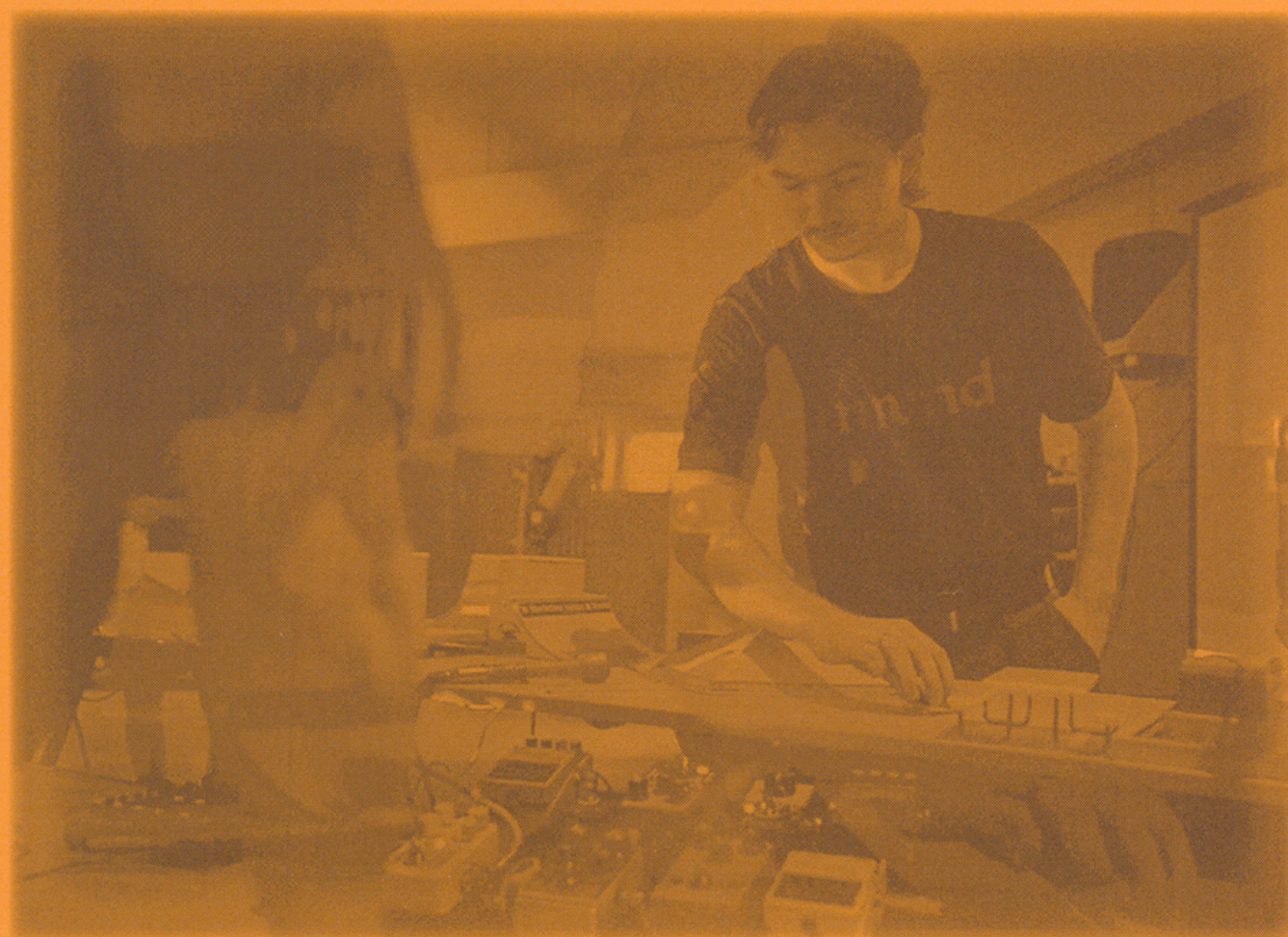


PHOTO BY GREG LOCKE